



THE AUTHOR SHALL HAVE THE SOLE RIGHT OF PRINTING

THE STATUTE OF ANNE (1710)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Copyright law

BEFORE

1545 The Venetian Republic's Council of Ten forbids the printing of a book without the author's permission.

1557 Queen Mary I gives the Stationers' Company exclusive rights to print books in England.

AFTER

1790 The US Copyright Act gives authors copyright for 14 years.

1842 The UK Copyright Act gives authors copyright for life plus 7 years (now 70 years after an author's death).

1886 Signatory nations of the Berne Convention agree to respect international copyright.

2019 The EU Directive on Copyright puts the onus on internet service providers to stop copyright infringement.

In the Middle Ages, when trained scribes painstakingly hand-copied manuscripts for monasteries, universities, and the wealthy elite, the right to copy was not an issue. All changed in around 1440, when German goldsmith Johannes Gutenberg invented the printing press. Using movable metal type, presses could produce multiple copies of a text cheaply and quickly for a new readership.

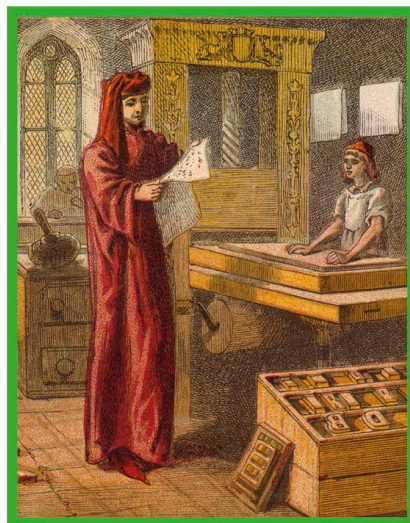
By 1500, 1,000 presses had produced about 8 million books in Western Europe. William Caxton brought the first printing press to

England in 1476. Printers realized they would suffer if other printers sold copies of the same book and sought to establish copyright to protect their commercial interests.

The royal hand

In England, King Henry VIII decreed in 1538 that the Court of Star Chamber must approve all new books before publication—a bid to prevent any considered subversive or heretical. His daughter Queen Mary went further by assigning the right to print books solely to the Stationers' Company, a publishing trade guild. Each book had to be entered by a guild member in the Stationers' register, giving them exclusive printing rights—the author simply received a small fee.

The rebel parliament that would eventually overthrow King Charles I abolished the Star Chamber in 1640, but its restrictive monopoly persisted through the Stationers. It provoked the poet John Milton to pen his angry polemic *Areopagitica*



William Caxton reads a page from his printing press in Westminster, London. The first book known to have been printed on it was *The Canterbury Tales* by Geoffrey Chaucer.